

AACE
INTERNATIONAL
**RECOMMENDED
PRACTICE**

38R-06

DOCUMENTING THE SCHEDULE BASIS

SAMPLE

AACE

INTERNATIONAL

June 18, 2009 (Ed. Rev. August 6, 2025)



AAACE® International Recommended Practice No. 38R-06

DOCUMENTING THE SCHEDULE BASIS

TCM Framework: 7.2 – Schedule Planning and Development

Rev. June 18, 2009 (Ed. Rev. August 6, 2025)

Quality Assurance Review (QAR) August 6, 2025

Note: As AAACE International Recommended Practices evolve over time, please refer to web.aacei.org for the latest revisions.

Any terms found in AAACE Recommended Practice 10, 90, *Cost Engineering Terminology*, supersede terms defined in other AAACE work products including but not limited to, other recommended practices, the *Total Cost Management Framework*, and *Skills & Knowledge of Cost Engineering*.

Contributors:

Disclaimer: The content provided by the contributors to this recommended practice is their own and does not necessarily reflect that of their employers, unless otherwise stated.

August 6, 2025 Revision:

Edward E. Douglas, III CCP PSP FAACE Hon. Life
(Primary Contributor)

June 18, 2009 Revision:

Edward E. Douglas, III CCC PSP (Primary Contributor)
Rodney B. Adams, CCE
Zia Akhtar
Thilak M. Bandara
Peter R. Bredehoeft, Jr. CEP
John P. Buziak, PE
Timothy T. Calvey, PE PSP
Dr. Tadashi Eguchi
Douglas A. Findley, CCC PSP
Dennis Read Hanks, PE CCE
Sanjay Kelkar

Joseph O. Kikiowo
Yingsheng Li
Gregory N. McDowell, CCC
Bill Mendelsohn, EVP
Steven S. Pinnell, PE
Amit Sarkar
Hannah E. Schumacher, PSP
H. Lance Stephenson, CCC
Donald F. Sulzer
Manan N. Vakil, CCE EVP PSP
Ronald M. Winter, PSP

Copyright © AAACE® International

Single user license only. Copying and networking prohibited.

AAACE® International Recommended Practices

This document is copyrighted by AAACE International and may not be reproduced without permission. Organizations may obtain permission to reproduce a limited number of copies by entering into a license agreement. For information please contact editor@aacei.org

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Table of Contents	1
1. Introduction	2
1.1. Scope	2
1.2. Purpose	2
1.3. Background	2
2. Recommended Practice	2
3. Information Sources – Schedule Basis	3
3.1. Project Description and Schedule Integration Process	3
3.2. Scope of Work	4
3.3. Execution Strategy	4
3.4. Key Project Dates	5
3.5. Planning Basis	5
3.6. Critical Path	6
3.7. Path of Execution	6
3.8. Punchlist, Turnover, and System Startup	6
3.9. Issues and Concerns	6
3.10. Risks and Opportunities	6
3.11. Assumptions	7
3.12. Exclusions	7
3.13. Exceptions	7
3.14. Baseline Changes/Reconciliation	7
3.15. Schedule Reserve	8
3.16. Project Buy-In	8
3.17. A Graded Approach	8
4. Scheduling Techniques and Software	8
References	9
Contributors	10
Appendix A. Format for the Basis of the Schedule	11

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Scope

This recommended practice (RP) provides an outline and describes a format for the various elements of information that may be included in the schedule basis document. This RP describes the important elements of schedule information that may be included to document the basis and assumptions of this project management tool. This recommended practice includes a checklist in the appendix that can be used to confirm that the elements of the basis document have been considered.

The schedule basis is a document that defines the basis for the development of the project schedule and assists the project team and stakeholders in identifying any key elements, issues and special considerations (assumptions, exclusions, risks/ opportunities, etc.). The project schedule represents the complete logical time-phased representation of the project plan. The schedule basis document may accompany the submittal of the project baseline schedule.

The schedule basis further substantiates the confidence and degree of completeness of the project schedule in order to support change management, reconciliation, and analysis. This document also doubles as a tool for assisting any personnel who are transitioning into the project and may be used in claims situations to illustrate a change of scope.

1.2. Purpose

This AACE International recommended practice is intended to provide a guideline, not to establish a standard for documenting the schedule basis for the planning of projects. The recommended practice is written and intended primarily for use on construction projects by the project team members and stakeholders involved in the planning and scheduling of the project work activities. These guidelines may be applicable to many other types of projects. The focus of this recommended practice is on documenting the necessary elements of the schedule basis. Refer to *TCM Framework* section “7.2.2.8 Establish Schedule Control Basis”. [1]

Many project individuals and groups contribute to the planning and development of the project schedule. By documenting the schedule basis, the project team captures the coordinated project schedule development process, which is by nature unique for most construction projects. This improves the final quality and adds value to the project baseline schedule, which serves as the time management navigation tool to guide the project team toward successful project completion. The schedule basis also is an important document used to identify changes during the schedule change management process.

1.3. Background

The requirement to document the basis of the schedule has been an established procedure for several years with many large corporations and some federal agencies. [2] This recommended practice describes the important elements of schedule information that may be included to document the basis and assumptions of this project management tool.

2. RECOMMENDED PRACTICE

Documentation of the schedule basis is an important step in reaching the objective for successful use of the project schedule. Describing the various elements of information in the schedule basis document will provide a better

understanding of what is or is not included and what is specifically excluded in the project schedule. A structured approach to that schedule documentation will eliminate much of that uncertainty and provide a clearer understanding of the schedule.

Documenting the basis of the cost estimate (BOE) is a generally accepted practice. That estimate basis is frequently used as a reference related to change management as the project moves forward. Many projects however, have invested less effort or have been less interested in documenting the basis of the project schedule for a variety of reasons. The lack of schedule documentation makes it difficult for the project participants to fully understand the overall planning that was incorporated in the project's schedule, which can have serious adverse effects on the ultimate success or failure of the project to achieve completion in the time forecast in that baseline schedule. Therefore, the basis of that planning process should be documented, as the project schedule is prepared. The schedule basis is not a "one size fits all" document. Using a graded approach for small projects is recommended. Preparation of the schedule basis document should begin concurrently with the first summary version of the project schedule and evolve into further detail as the schedule is developed. The schedule basis should be a life cycle document relating to the baseline schedule and both should be referenced and updated as the project progresses in accordance with the project change management process. Preparation and maintenance of the schedule basis document is the responsibility of the project entity responsible for preparing and maintaining the project schedule. The basis for the project schedule may be organized in an outline similar to a cost estimate basis outline. The schedule basis document describes essential elements of information such as those listed below:

- Project Description, Schedule Integration Process
- Scope of Work
- Execution Strategy
- Key Project Dates
- Planning Basis
- Critical Path
- Path of Execution
- Punchlist, Turnover, and System Startup
- Issues and Concerns
- Risks and Opportunities
- Assumptions
- Exclusions
- Exceptions
- Baseline Changes/Reconciliation
- Schedule Reserve
- Project Buy-In

3. INFORMATION SOURCES – SCHEDULE BASIS

3.1. Project Description and Schedule Integration Process

This section of the schedule basis may briefly and concisely provide a high-level description of the project. Since this document provides the basis for the development of the schedule, it may also describe the process and personnel involved in developing the project schedule. The phase of the project (i.e., conceptual, design, procurement, execution, or startup) should also be included in this section of the basis, so that there is an early understanding of the overall completeness of the project design, and procurement information can be determined. The schedule basis document should be updated periodically as the project development progresses as well as when there are any major changes of scope or performance requirements for the project. A checklist may be attached to indicate the available project information (and the degree of completeness). This provides the reader with an understanding of the completeness of the information used during schedule development. The schedule integration process would